CARBON CRUSADER

His business, as Dabkara jokes himself, is a little hard to explain, even to his family members. A professor at a private engineering college in Bhopal where he studied introduced him to the idea of energy audits. After a master's in Energy and Environment Management and a paid internship with French firm SGS in 2007, Dabkara set up his proprietorship firm, EnKing International, in 2008 out of his home in Mhow. He was offered his first project in 2009—carbon credit consulting by Param Capital, a Mumbai-based company. As more projects came in, Dabkara hired a team of 20 people and office space in Indore.

In 2011, Dabkara incorporated EnKing International into EKI Energy Services Ltd, supplying as well as developing carbon credits. Today, the company is one of the top five carbon credit project developers in the world with a turnover of Rs 1,800 crore, 250 employees, a presence in 16 countries and more than 3,000 clients in 40 countries.

Among other businesses, EKI is also making energy-efficient wood fired stoves for Shell, which distributes them free to reduce its carbon footprint. The company has also set up a 'climate impact fund' in Singapore to finance green projects.

In the days to come, EKI plans to get into carbon-backed crypto currency, and is also in the process of acquiring sustainability-related software. Dabkara also plans to advise companies to use CSR funds to train manpower to claim carbon credits.

-Rahul Noronha

MANISH KUMAR DABKARA, 38

Indore, Madhya Pradesh

Company
EKI Energy Services Ltd

Net Worth
Rs 3,500 crore



HARDIK CHHABRA

lems households in lower-tier cities face, says Gandhi. Entrepreneurs here, therefore, build solutions catering to their unique issues. Asha Ventures has invested in Adda247, an ed-tech company that helps over 20 million students annually, 90 per cent of them from outside the metros, prepare for exams for government jobs. Then there is Ritesh Aggarwal of Oyo, the online hotel booking site, and Bhavish Agarwal of cab aggregator Ola Cabs, both Tier II townsmen who built organisations of scale.

Covid and the growth of the distributed workforce also fostered deeper innovation and wealth distribution, with a greater share of wages going into Tier II locations. "Meanwhile," says Gandhi, "the Indian government, too, has been working with various stakeholders for more equitable distribution of capital by fostering innovation ecosystems in each state, helping startups connect with state governments and venture investors, and even holding annual rankings of innovation societies in these states to drive competition." The Atal Innovation Mission is one such enabler, providing platforms and collaboration opportunities for different stakeholders in the country, through its 1,000-plus Atal Tinkering Labs and nearly 70 Atal Innovation Centres.

Small Town, Big Opportunity

An enabling environment certainly helps, but there is more that characterises the small-town entrepreneur. The Patni brothers of Kishangarh in Ajmer, for instance, were quick to sense a business opportunity in mining marble, inspiring a shift from their traditional business of wholesale trading in foodgrains to embark on a journey that has seen them become the largest producers of marble in the world, exporting to